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AGRARIAN TROUBLES IN THE UNITED PROVINCES

As one of the General Secretaries of the Congress and a member of the Working Committee, I was in touch with All-India politics and occasionally had to do some touring also, though I avoided this as far as possible. As our burdens and responsibilities grew, the meetings of the Working Committee became longer and longer, till they developed into a regular sessions of two weeks at a time. It was no longer a question of merely passing resolutions of criticism, but of controlling numerous different kinds of constructive activities of a vast and many-sided organisation, and of tackling, from day to day, difficult problems on whose handling depended conflict or otherwise on a nation-wide scale.

My chief activities, however, lay in the United Provinces where the agrarian situation absorbed Congress attention. The U.P. Provincial Congress Committee consisted of over a hundred and fifty members, and met every two or three months. Its Executive Council, consisting of about fifteen members, met frequently and was in charge of its agrarian department.

In the second half of the year 1931, a special Agrarian Committee was appointed by this Council. It is interesting to find that several zamindars were prominently associated with the Council and this Committee throughout, and all steps were taken with their approval. Indeed, the President of our Provincial Committee for the year (and consequently the *ex-officio* head of the Executive Council and the Agrarian Committee) was Tasadduq Ahmad Khan Sherwani, who belongs to a well-known zamindari family. The General Secretary, Sri Prakasa, as well as several leading members of the Council were also zamindars, or were members of zamindari families. The remaining members were middle-class professional people. There was not a single tenant or poor peasant representative in our provincial executive. Peasants were to be found in our District Committees, but they seldom survived the various elections which ultimately resulted in the formation of the Executive Council for the province, which was a body entirely dominated by the middle-class intelligentsia with a strong zamindari leaven in it.